A New Way to Bleed

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A New Way to Bleed

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Summary

It's so easy…

…pushing someone over the edge.

Notes

Let me begin by saying I'm okay for now.
Yes, that means I may not be okay going forward, but unfortunately, there is nothing any of you can do.
Please don't feel like you *have* to do something either.

I write this because it helps me, and maybe, it can help someone else.

I originally intended to post this on my birthday on the 9th, but… Tonight I'm doubting if I'll make it till next week at all.
Again, don't worry about me. Don't waste energy.
I'm not looking for attention, but rather hoping the sublimation of all this bullshit can help me, and perhaps help someone else reading this.

Final note: the representation of Castaspella's family i write here is a super fictionalization of my own. But with key details altered. My mother is not like Casta's mother, at least not that extreme, my brother is my personal hell but here Micah is one of the few anchors Casta has because I wish my brother was like that, and my father used to be the real problem, not anymore, yet he's quite inactive, like the father here. As for the relationship between Casta and LS, I don't care in the slightest about whether it is "toxic" or not. I mean that. Their relationship is what I wish I could have (my gf is long distance!) and may not be what a professional would recommend, but it's certainly what my little heart longs for.

That's all.
Ah, and comment moderation enabled just in case.

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

> Casta and Micah's mother's "adopted" name is Celia, her real name is Akane (the woman does usually wear deep red) - When LS uses that real name, everyone knows she's *pissed*
>
> Casta and Micah don't have japanese names, tho Casta does have a "real" name, Esmeralda, because Castaspella is actually a nick name Micah gave her

See the end of the chapter for more notes

When Light Spinner arrived home, a terrible feeling, like a cold hand, gripped her heart.

She had no idea what was going on, but she knew it was something bad.

So before taking another step inside, or even closing the door, she picked up her phone and dialed Micah's number.

—*Hello?*

—Micah. You must come to my place.

—*Who- Light Spinner?*

—Are you listening to me!? Come, *now*.

—*What- Why!?*

—Just do it!

—*Alright! I'm on my way!*

Without another word, she hang up.

Now, she had to find the source of her bad feeling, and a part of her already anticipated it.

She did not want it to be true, but… it'd be worse if she dallied.

When Micah arrived at the appartment Light Spinner and his sister shared, the door was still open.

What had happened!?

Hesitant, he pushed the door opened and it creaked, making him flinch.

—Micah!?— a voice called.

—Yes! Light Spinner!?

—Come! Quick!— she called. —I've already called the ambulance.

Ambulance!?

—What do you… mean?— he asked, rushing inside, and feeling breahtless for a moment when he stepped into the bedroom. —What- Is she…

—She's still alive. For now…

Next to the bed, sitting on the floor, Light Spinner held between her arms Castaspella's limp body.

She did look dead.

Micah felt his legs shake as she tried to step closer, and finally fell to his knees in front of them.

He couldn't tear his eyes off of his sister's neck, where bloody scratches criss-crossed.

—What… happened to her?

Light Spinner looked back at him with a mix of sorrow and disdain.

—Must I explain?

—What?

—What do you think?

—I don't…

—Yes, you know. It's happened before— she insisted.

—She- No, why-why would she…

—I don't *know*— the woman spoke, pointing each word in frustration. She then sighed and looked down at her partner, on the verge of tears. With her voice broken, she admitted —I had no idea she was… I could have avoided this.

—Wait. Do-don't blame yourself— Micah immediately replied, shaking his head. —I was with her yesterday and she was fine. It-it may have been something… more recent.

—This isn't caused by a one-time thing. This- Reaching this point- It must have been building up for a while and now she just exploded— Light Spinner guessed.

—We won’t know for sure until she wakes up.

—Once the ambulance comes, I’ll need you to go with her— she requested.

—Why won’t you go?

—I have to check things here. I need to make sure she didn’t take any pills or anything strange… And just… I have to- I want to make sure she didn’t prepare this.

—I see— Micah nodded. —I hope you won’t… find anthing that suggests that.

Hearing the blaring of an approaching ambulance, Light Spinner thought of one last question.

—The last time, when she- Do you still remember what the note said?

—Not much. It was just an apology…

—So I thought— she nodded, lifting Castaspella and passing her onto his arms. —If she wakes up before I arrive, just tell her I’ll be there soon. Don’t mention *why*, though.

—Of course— he nodded, resolute.

Right then, they heard footsteps approach and so Micah stood up, carrying his sister, and headed for the door. A pair of nurses bringing a blue stretcher met him at the door and took her down to the ambulance, to where he silently followed.

Meanwhile, in the apartment, Light Spinner began counting the blisters of medication.

Only one sleeping pill was missing. Alright, that was good.

She didn’t have an overdose then.

She then searched up and down, every room, but found no note. That was also good.

It wasn’t attempted suicide.

Castaspella must have been triggered by *something*, and because of all the building feelings, probably exploded.

That had to be it.

But to be sure, Light Spinner decided to do something she *knew* was wrong.

Without so much as a grunt and a eyeroll, the old woman opened a drawer next to the bed and pulled out a notebook with a plain cover.

She then sat on the bed and went directly to the last written page.

—You’ll have to forgive me, Es…

The last entry of the journal wasn't far from what she expected, and it explained a few things…

She did it again

Why!? Why does my mother ALWAYS have something to say!?

I can't take it. I just CAN'T

I took a pill to sleep this off, but… It's SO DIFFICULT

I hate this! I hate everything! I want to scream!

There was a loose stroke of pen almost over the text, and Light Spinner visualized for a moment what may have happened.

Castaspella probably got overwhelmed, threw the notebook and pen, scratched herself, and only then, once her mind "cleared", she picked everything up, put it all in its place, and likely sat there on the ground, crying until the pill finally made her fall asleep where Light Spinner found her.

But that was all speculation.

To know for sure, she'd have to speak with her partner.

After reading a bit more, and discovering Castaspella had been lying about both her diet and the frequency of her showers, the old woman put everything back in place and left the apartment to head for the hospital.

Castaspella was just opening her eyes when Light Spinner walked into the room.

—Oh, I was about to call you— Micah told her, surprised by her arrival.

—Impecable timing, obviously— she smirked, before looking at her partner and allowing herself to be a bit more gloomy. —Es… how are you feeling?

—Bea…— she let out, voice hoarse. —Sorry.

—Don't apologize to *me*, Love— she sighed, shaking her head. —I don't want to make you feel even worse, so… forget it. Just, please, talk to me— she pleaded.

—What… do you… want me to… tell you?

—Just the truth: what happened?

—Mom… sent some… messages— Castaspella managed to say, before coughing. After Light Spinner passed her a glass with some water, she took small sips and tried to continue — It doesn't… matter what. Just- She just said- She made me feel… *awful*.

—Listen, Es. I need you to be honest. You can just nod or shake your head if talking is hurting you— the old woman decided to tell her. —I have been asking whether you're eating. You told me you are. Is that true? Have you *really* been eating?

—Ye-yes…— she replied, voice strained. —But… not always.

—And what about showering?— she added. Castaspella shook her head, looking away, and Micah gave Light Spinner a confused look. —You don't need to lie to me, you know?

—Sorry…

—It's alright— she sighed, pressing a kiss on Castaspella's forehead through the veil. —But…

—But?

—I'll have a word with your mother.

—No…

—Yes.

—But, Bea…

—I can't let this pass— Light Spinner insisted.

—It's not the first time.

—I am well aware.

—Then I'll go too.

—I don't want you close to that woman anymore.

—I need some… stuff from home. Then, maybe, I can… stay away.

—Alright, then, we'll do that— she sighed. —You get your things, I speak with your mother — Light Spinner accepted. —Can you accompany us, Micah?

—Sure… When?

—As soon as Es can leave— she replied. —Until then, you rest, Young Lady— she then told Castaspella.

She certainly didn't want to, but had to spend the night at the hospital.

Light Spinner kept her company, Micah went home, and only returned the next day when her sister got discharged.

He drove them to his parents' home, and waited a moment before unlocking the doors of the car.

—Are we sure about this?

—Es?— Light Spinner asked too, redirecting the question to Castaspella.

—Yeah. But… I'll wait outside first— she said, a hand resting over the bandages on her neck. —You tell me when I can come in.

—Don't wait alone outside, Casta— Micah pleaded. —At least wait on the genkan.

—Sure— she sighed.

With that, the three stepped out of the car, and Micah led the way into the house, more like a traditional Japanese mansion.

As agreed, Castaspella sat on the anteroom while her brother and her partner took off their shoes to step inside.

Micah ventured first into the tokonoma, found his father sitting with a book, and silently greeted him when he looked up.

Light Spinner remained barely a few steps behind, also greeted the man with a respectful bow, and took a deep breath, expecting the "lady of the house" to appear out of nowhere anytime now.

And she did.

—Well, well. Look who's here— the woman began, sliding aside the fusuma that divided the room where she was, from the tokonoma. —I wonder what brings *you* here again.

—Mo-Mother— Micah stammered.

—Son…— she replied, cold. —Every time you bring this woman to our home, she leaves with yet another one of our possessions. What have you brought her to get this time?— she asked, already offended.

—I didn't- She's here to *talk*. About Casta.

—What about your sister?

—I literally told you yesterday that- Ugh. Dad— he began, then interrupted himself, frustrated, and looked at his father. —Did she tell you that I called yesterday?

The man shook his head in silence.

Light Spinner knew he was a man of few words, but sometimes she considered the possibility that his wife had cut off his tongue.

—Leave it, Micah. I'll handle it— she decided to intercede. —Whether you know or not, Esmeralda was taken to the hospital yesterday after I found her passed out with scratches on her neck— she began, calling the father's attention, but barely making the mother raise a brow. —She claims it was because of the contents of certain messages you sent her, Celia— she then explained.

—Right. The poor thing is so *unstable*. Can't tell her anything without making her cry.

—That's *not* true!— Micah immediately rebuked.

—Do you not care about your daughter in the slightest!? Do you not realize the influence your words have over her!? Some level of *bitch* you have to be…

—Takes one to know one— Celia replied, rolling her eyes.

And Light Spinner doubled down.

With a smirk, she asked —Why do you think I'm saying it?

Both Micah and his father face-palmed at the same time, so hard it could be heard, while the women glared daggers at each other.

—You *insolent child*!

—You're calling *me* a child!?— Light Spinner scoffed. —Wasn't I "too old" for your daughter!?

—I could still be your mother…

—No, you could not— she immediately denied. —With that personality, my father would have killed you before you could bare any children.

Celia gasped, indignant, and looked at her husband, as if asking to be defended or something…

He didn't say a word.

—So…— Micah decided to intercede. —Are we sure about this?— he asked Light Spinner.

—Of course. She said she wanted to, so let her come in, take her things while we *talk*.

Hesitant, Micah went to get Castaspella.

He wanted this to be over as soon as possible too.

Meanwhile, Celia raised a brow as she let out —Don't tell me… She's come to ask for something once more…

—If it were for me, she'd never set foot here again, but I won't dictate her life, opposite to *you*— Light Spinner replied, snarling.

—Right… as if I would ever "dictate" such a pathetic life…— Celia scoffed, rolling her eyes and gesturing dismissively with a hand, right as Castaspella walked in. —All her mistakes are hers and hers alone.

—*My mistakes*!?— she immediately cried out, stopping on her tracks.

—Wait, Casta…— Micah tried to stop her, but she did *not* stop.

—Look at me! Look at my neck! Look at what you've done!— she yelled, ripping off the bandages that covered the scratches.

Light Spinner's hands immediately closed into tight fists, knuckles turning white, and she glared back at Celia.

As expected, her expression only supported her words just before. A stark contrast to her husband, who covered his mouth with both hands and seemed on the verge of tears.

—What *I* have done!? Don't go blaming me for your own foolishness…— she spat.

—My- Agh!— Castaspella cried again, falling on her knees, holding her head. —Why… can't you…

—Enough!— Ligth Spinner finally sentenced. —Micah, take her to pick up what she needs and let's get going— she first ordered, as he helped his sister stand up again. —And you. You and I will talk one last time, Akane.

—It's *Celia* for you!

—I will call you your real name, so *maybe* you will listen!

—Are you going to allow this!?— she asked her husband, indignant.

—I can't stop her…

—Indeed, he can't. So you will listen: I am not letting you kill your daughter. I am not sitting to watch how she consumes herself because of your stupid *worthless* words. So this is the last time you'll see her. The last time you'll speak to her. Unless you apologize, and vow to treat her better, I will make sure you're no longer part of her life!

—You can't do that.

—I can, and I will.

—You will not.

—Watch me.

The women glared at each other for what felt like an eternity before Micah called Ligth Spinner over to Castaspella's room.

—E-excuse me. Can you help? I need to get something…

—You have ten minutes to decide, Akane. Apologize, or lose your child. If you still care for her *at all*, the choice should be simple enough— she concluded, heading to her partner's bedroom. —Es, how are you?

—I'm… sorry.

—Don't apologize. You shouldn't have taken off the bandages, though— Light Spinner sighed, sitting next to her on the bed and observing the bandages that, probably, Micah had put back in place. —Do you have everything you need?

—It's just two attires that-that mean a lot to me…— she replied, sobbing. —I didn't bring… anything to carry them on.

—Do we have no bags or luggage…— she was asking, when Castaspella suddenly grabbed her hands and interrupted.

—Do you really mean it?

—Mean what?

—What you just told my mother.

—We discussed this.

—Well, yes, but…

—But what, Es?

—With how similar you are, I didn't think…

—I'm really that similar?

—Yes… Quite— Castaspella sighed, looking away.

—Holy shit— the woman let out, disgruntled. —I have to apologize to those kids.

—Really?— her partner slightly laughed, unable to believe it. —You would…

—Right now. We leave here and stop by Adora's. I'm sure Catra will be there— Light Spinner nodded, resolute. —If I remind you of your mother, then I must have done something *very* wrong.

Tearing up, Castaspella threw her arms around the old woman's neck and hugged her tightly, sobbing —Thank you.

Chapter End Notes

This is what I have for now, and it's a bit messy.

Unfortunately, I already have *more* material to continue this, but again, I'm still here…
Somehow.

Whatever. Just… think about it.
It's easy to push someone over the edge.
Words have weight. No words are meaningless.
What we say, how we say it, can uphold or destroy lives.
Someone might be saved by our words.
Someone might die for our words.
It shouldn't be like this, but it is.

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

So… unfortunately, I'm back with more
Fortunately, I *am* back at least. So, that's a win?

Anyways
This ended up longer than expected, turns out I had a LOT to "say", so to speak, and here it all is
Gotta mention: I'm projecting everything I feel into Casta, and everything my brother does to me into Casta's mother. And it makes *even less sense with me* because, like, a mother is an authority figure, so ofc Casta would feel like she can't hate her and give so much importance to her every word. But I do that with my brother (younger!), so why the fuck can't I simply hate the little shit or ignore him, or whatever? No idea. What authority does he have to criticize me? None, but he thinks he's above everyone, so…

ANYWAYS
This was very cathartic.

Let's hope there won't be much more *that soon*

After Light Spinner fulfilled her word and visited Adora and Catra solely to apologize for how she may have behaved while they were under her charge, they returned home and Castaspella sat on the bed feeling strange.

Part of her wanted to fill her journal with her current thoughts, but the truth was that she had no energy for that right now.

And yet, that was *nothing* compared to her lack of energy to take a bath.

Oh, no, that was *not* happening this day.

Instead, she asked Light Spinner to tell her how it went with the girls.

—I told Micah why we stopped by their house and all, and he could hardly believe it— Castaspella giggled. —So we came up with a few theories of how they may have rected— she admitted, sheepish.

—I'm sure neither of you could have imagined it— the old woman smirked. —But I think we have *other* things to discuss, Young Lady. Like when was the last time you took a bath…

—Oh, no…— she complained, leaning back on the mattress. —Come on! Just tell me how it went…

—Look, I realize it's important to you, but it is also important to me that you take care of yourself, and that includes having regular showers, with no more than a single day between each— Light Spinner insisted.

—Bea…

—Let's make a deal: I'll tell you how it went, *then* I'll prepare something for us to eat, and *meanwhile*, you will take a quick shower at the very least.

—Fine…— Castaspella agreed, albeit with a pout.

—Good. Well, as you can imagine, they were surprised by my visit, and completely shocked when I explained the reason— Light Spinner began. —So I mentioned without much detail, that I know someone who treats her daughter so bad it was taking a turn for the worst, and since being compared to that person, I understood I likely made them feel awful with themselves, and possibly put them in a situation I loathe, for which I had gone to apologize.

—And what did they say?

—They admitted they had been, in fact, near the edge, so to speak, because of my… idiocy. But they had each other, and that seems to have saved them from the worst— Light Spinner explained. —I think you're more alone than them in that sense. Maybe Micah and I are here for you, but we don't suffer *with you* the same as you, which is the main difference with them — she further clarified. —I told them I understood why they left to leave on their own as soon as they could, but they appreciated my apology and said they wouldn't mind future visits.

Smiling, Castaspella pushed herself up from the bed and hugged Light Spinner tightly.

—I'm so glad— she uttered, voice broken and tears threatening to fall. —You have no idea how happy that makes me.

—I imagine— the old woman sighed, hugging her back. —I won't tell you that your mother could ever see how wrong she is and apologize too, but… I imagine you'll hold onto that hope forever.

—Yeah…— Castaspella lamented. —I'm sorry.

—Don't apologize— Light Spinner replied, looking at her now with certain severity. —Just be honest with me. Ask for my help if you need it, even if all you need is someone to hear you express yourself. I *know* I'm not the best with feelings, and yes, I'll likely get angry at whomever makes you miserable. But I'd rather make the effort to control myself than leave you alone in this.

—And I appreciate that— she replied, cheeks wet. —I'm still sorry. I make you suffer too. And that was never the intention.

—I know— the old woman sighed. —I understand it's hard. But that's also why I will insistently remind you of basic self-care— she then pointed out, smirking. —Like taking a

shower now.

—Ugh… Fine! Fine…

—I'll prepare something. Tea or coffee?

—I'd like some coffee this time.

—And to eat?

—Do we have anything left from the last time we ordered desserts?

—I don't think so— Light Spinner hummed. —But I can always order more. Baklava?

—And Kadayif, please— Castaspella smiled.

—Alright. I'll make that call, prepare the coffee, and *you* will take a shower *and* wash your hair.

—Hey! That was *not* part of the deal!

—Es…

—I don't want to wash my hair…— she lamented.

—Esmeralda, you *must* wash you hair. *Please*.

—It takes *forever*! And then I *also* have to dry it off!

—Alright, alright— Light Spinner interrupted, taking a deep breath. —What of I dry it off for you? Just wash it, put on a towel, and I'll handle the rest.

—Are you sure?

—Yes.

—Ah… Fine— Castaspella agreed, with a long sigh.

Light Spinner had almost forgotten, so to speak, about the scratches Castaspella had inflicted herself.

Of course she could see them, but she wasn't that worried anymore.

She had *innocently* allowed herself to believe it was "in the past" instead of an active issue.

But then it was nighttime and she could *swear* Castaspella was actively trying to keep her legs covered.

—Es…

—Hmm?

—Show me your legs.

—Excuse me!?

—Now.

—No!— she scoffed, indignant, curled up on the bed, holding her legs close to her chest.

—Look. I have a reason to do this. I'm trying to take care of you. So do me a favour and let me see your legs.

—No! Why!?

—You wouldn't have a problem with it if you had nothing to hide.

—Beatrix, what the actual fuck!?

—Please— she begged, trying to calm down as Castaspella kept recoiling further and further away from her.

—No- I-I have nothing to hide— she stammered, shaking her head.

—Es, my Love…

—Beatrix, please— she pleaded, eyes watering.

—Esmeralda, I won't scold you or anything— she assured her, trying to ease her fear. —Just… please. Let me… see.

Castaspella kept looking away, swallow hard, but finally stretched her legs and pulled up her nightgown.

There was nothing.

—You're right. I did- I did scratch… my legs. But… my nails are short since yesterday, so…

—What happened? And when?— Light Spinner asked, sitting closer on the bed and carefully caressing her legs. But she seemed unwilling to talk. —Let me guess then: Was it at your parents? While you waited on the genkan?— she inquired, and Castaspella nodded. —You heard your mother, didn't you?

—Why did she have to… *say that*!?

—I'm sorry— the old woman sighed, embracing her. —I shouldn't have left you alone where you could hear her.

—It's not your fault. I *know* it shouldn't affect me, but I can't!

—True, you shouldn't give a fuck about whatever she says, but she's still your mother, so of course you care— Light Spinner pointed out. —That's why I told her I wouldn't let her be in your life anymore.

—How!?

—We'll start simple: block her number.

—Huh!?

—Block her number in your phone. Don't let her send you any more messages. If something truly important happens, your father or Micah can let you know.

—I… No, no, I can't block my mother…

—Her *every word* to you is mean, unconstructive, purposely nasty— Light Spinner remarked. —Do yourself a favour. Protect yourself, Es. Please.

—But… Ah… She'll only get mad if I do that…

—Then let her be mad. I don't care if I have to get a legal order, I *will* keep her away from you, and I *will* keep you *safe*.

—A-alright— Castaspella finally nodded, still not fully convinced.

Something told Light Spinner she might not block her, or even end up unblocking her the next day.

But she couldn't control her phone as if she were a baby.

She would not do that to her partner.

Or try…

The following day was Sunday, and the question of Casta returning to work haunted the women.

Could she?

She was just the college librarian, but still… what if someone asked about her neck? It was the middle of spring! She couldn't cover it up convincingly…

So they lay in bed for a long while, hugging each other, until Castaspella's phone rang with a message from Angella.

—What does she want a Sunday at ten in the morning?— Light Spinner complained, reluctantly letting Castaspella pick up her phone.

—Ah…— she let out, reading the message. —She got Micah to tell her.

—Great— the old woman muttered. —And?

—She says I can take some time off… but I…

—You don't want to. I know. I think you should, but I'll be honest: I don't want to leave you here on your own for so long.

—I don't want to be alone that long either— Castaspella admitted. Immediately, she typed a reply and, soon, Angella answered back. —Okay, she says she won't force me to rest, but asks the million gold question: how will I cover it.

—Tell her we'll figure something out…

So she replied once more…

And then got a new message.

—She's… inviting us to visit? What?

—For what?

—Doesn't say.

—Fine. Let's go. I wanted to talk to Micah, anyways. But after lunch. I don't want to get up yet— Light Spinner grumbled.

—Sure.

As agreed, that afternoon they visited Angella and Micah, and were surprised that Glimmer *wasn't* there for once.

Since moving out, she had been there when they visited, practically every time…

In any case, Angella took Castaspella to a different room almost immediately, leaving Micah and Light Spinner alone.

—Don't worry. She'll just find her something comfortable to cover her neck so she can go to work tomorrow— he told the old woman, who hadn't noticed how disgruntled she looked.

—Right. Right…— she nodded. —In that case, we can talk.

—Oh, yeah, we must— he agreed, sitting at the table and inviting her to join him. —I've been meaning to ask: what was that about eating and showering that you told Casta at the hospital?

—Listen… Your sister has very clear tells of when she's falling into depression, or most times they are that. She won't shower, due to lack of energy or motivation, if not both, and she won't eat unless fed.

—Okay?

—Leaving the bathing aside, I think the most important part here, which I missed, is when she skips meals *regardless* of there being food available.

—How's that?

—Your *dear mother* has been telling her she's "fat".

—Where!?

—Ask your mother! I don't see it either, trust me. She has volume, but she's fine, she's *certainly* not fat— Light Spinner agreed, wanting to match his indignation. —The thing is: most times it doesn't affect her. She rolls her eyes and happily eats her dumplings— she went on, chuckling slightly at the end. —You know what I mean.

—There's a but.

—There is. I don't know if she was more vulnerable lately, or what happened, or if the messages got more aggressive, but I noticed something. I just didn't associate it before last Friday— she explained. With a sigh, she elaborated —You know she likes to wear corsets sometimes. Or those tight belts, what are they called?

—Wait, which ones? Like the…

—Not the kimono ones, I mean the regular belt-like things that are purposely tight…

—Oh, wait, you mean a sash!?

—That, yes, thank you— she nodded. —Can't believe I forgot that… In any case, I know it sounds strange, but I have a reason to bring this up: thinking back, I seem to recall her tightening those more than usual. Either corsets or sashes, those are supposed to be tight, but not enough to make you *suffer*. Usually, she has them measured and doesn't need to tighten them anymore, but I can swear I saw her adjusting the damned corset last time she put it on, and I found a torn sash among the laundry.

—Wait… She- But…

—You see what I mean.

—So, Mother tells her she's "fat", and she basically strangles her body to… what? Prove her wrong?

—Not to prove her wrong, but rather *because* she was feeling fat.

—But she is *not*!

—It's a feeling, Micah, not the truth. That's also why she usually won't listen to her. Because it depends on whether she feels it to be true or not. And if I had noticed before, maybe…

—No, forget it. You couldn’t have known— he quickly interrupted. —Casta is just like that. She won’t tell you things if she’s ashamed of it, unless her guilt is bigger.

—You mean like that time, with the note.

—Yes— he sighed. —I think she felt more guilty of what she tried to do than ashamed.

—Can you tell me what happened back then?

—It was little after you met, but you already know that. There isn’t really much you *don’t* know about this, actually.

—I don’t know what the note said.

—Well, it wasn't *actually* a suicide note. It was… an apology.

—You mentioned that.

—Yes, but I mean: she was apologizing for attempting to- She had apparently tried to hurt herself with the intention of killing herself, but in the end couldn't. It was the first time, as far as the note said, and she apologized for that.

—That’s… certainly strange, but I see your point about her guilt being greater than her shame.

—I think she didn't mean for the note to be found. Like she regretted it last second and it was mere coincidence that we found it— he commented. —And, well, Mother was far from moved by it. In fact, she began with “oh, so I can’t tell her anything because she does *this*” and all that…

—That only encourages Es to hide whenever she does this— Light Spinner scoffed. —Again, it *is* strange to leave such note, but I also think she was looking for support. *Maybe*, if she let you know what had happened, you, as a family I mean, would show her support or whatever she needed.

—I tried. I told her she could talk to me… but- Ah… I guess she didn’t really feel safe.

—It’s not just you, either— she replied. —But we can’t force her to trust us, in any case.

—Then, what do we do?

—I don’t really know…

By the time Castaspella and Angella joined them again, it was already getting late and the women had to return home to have dinner and sleep.

It’d be a long Monday the next day, and Light Spinner wanted to have a word with her partner, alone, before they went to sleep.

So they soon left, agreeing to meet them again the following day on Campus to have breakfast together before each went to do their corresponding job…

Upon arriving at their appartment, Castaspella wanted to go directly to bed, but then again… dinner first.

—I'm really not hungry…

—Es, we didn't eat since lunch.

—But…

—At least something small. A soup, a sandwich… *something*— Light Spinner insisted.

—Bea, I'm serious. I don't want to eat anything.

—Did something happen?

—No… Don't start with the questioning, please— Castaspella begged.

—I don't want to question you, but I'm worried— she insisted, approaching her to embrace her waist. —Let me do something for you. Please.

After hesitating for a moment, she finally accepted —Some cheese and cold meat? Maybe?

—It's something at least— Light Spinner admitted, with a sad smile.

—Then I'll get changed and be right back.

With a light peck, Castaspella pulled herself away from her partner's arms and went to the bedroom, leaving her purse on the kitchen table.

Immediately, the old woman got an idea, which she hated but couldn't help contemplating.

She couldn't…

She *would never*…

But what if…

—No, no. I can't— she told herself, aloud, as if that would make any difference.

Yet it didn't.

After another minute of hesitation, she ended up fishing Castaspella's phone from her purse and unlocked it.

How she knew her password was something she had forgotten.

She did feel bad about this, part of her hoped Castaspella would return that exact moment before she could really go through her messages…

But she didn't.

Light Spinner didn't want to justify it, even to herself.

So she tortured herself instead, screaming internally as she browsed the chats to find the messages Celia had sent Castaspella.

It was a nightmare.

Light Spinner was gladly surprised to see she *had* blocked the number, but the array of messages prior to that was horrible.

All conversations were started by Castaspella, usually just saying "hi", sometimes asking her how she was doing, or how her father was doing.

Not a single time did her mother ask back, or even answer to begin with.

Every time, instead of *replying*, the woman would *attack*. There was no other word for it.

How could someone- Well, she knew people could be really spiteful. Light Spinner herself could be like that. But she wasn't- she *hoped* she wasn't *like that*!

Celia had nothing nice to say.

She certainly had *a lot* to say about virtually any subject in Castaspella's life, from partner choice, to career and work choice, all through wardrobe, diet, music, habits, and even friends.

But none of it was even remotely good!

In fact, she had nothing *neutral* to say.

Even things that could have been innocent comments were written in a manner that made them spiteful remarks.

Again, yes. Light Spinner herself could be like that, but…

She wasn't this bad. Right!?

Meanwhile, in the bedroom, Castaspella had finished changing into her nightgown and had sat to write on her journal.

She hesitated, unsure of what to write down, what to write about.

The good? The bad?

She went back a few pages, reread the times she wrote about her mother, the messages, her feelings…

She felt… Awful. Honestly awful.

Maybe she had to *try* to focus on the good for a bit.

She wrote about how much Micah and Light Spinner had been helping her. About her partner's decision to apologize to the girls after that argument with her mother. And about her recent attempts to help her take better care of herself.

But it was hard for herself to feel better. She wanted to feel joy, but none of the things she had brought her joy anymore, and she *knew* it was a problem with herself.

Maybe she needed to look for a new book, a new game, or even a new hobby…

She'd probably have time that Monday to find something like that.

But for now, that was enough.

She closed her journal, put it away, and finally headed to the kitchen, where she found Light Spinner just barely setting down a plate on the table with the cheese and cold meat she promised.

—Thank you— she muttered, sitting down. —I… imagine you wanna talk…— Castaspella then said, not daring to look at her.

—You are right.

—I can't promise I'll tell you everything.

—You don't have to promise that, but the more you tell me, the better I'll understand, and probably will be able to help you more.

—I want to… but… I don't- It's not that I don't trust you, but I can imagine how you'll react and I don't want to upset you in any way.

—And If I promise not to react?

—You can't promise that.

—Fair…

—So just… Ask whatever you want, but if I say you don't want to know the answer, then trust me and don't push it— Castaspella asked.

—Deal— Light Spinner accepted, sitting at the table in front of her with her own plate. —Let's begin with the messages you said you got on Friday.

—I told you- Ah, yes.

—What where those about?

—Well… about *you*.

—Fantastic— Light Spinner scoffed, rolling her eyes.

—Normally, I don't care in the slightest what she says about you, but she got so…

—Intrusive?

—Yes! She- I don't- Please, don't get mad, but… she thinks really high about marriage and all that stuff, and she *loves* to remind me that you and I can't get married and whatever, and I usually just tell her that I'd rather never do than marry someone else…— Castaspella began explaining, but interrupted herself for a second before concluding —And she said that's expected from me since I never matured.

Light Spinner clenched her teeth and closed her hands in fists, pretending to be more annoyed than she was.

She had read that already, so it wasn't as shocking now, but what truly infuriated her was seeing Castaspella so insecure and ashamed as she told her all of this.

—Es. You are not "childish". And even if you were, it would *not* be a bad thing— she began. —However, I must mention that it sounds like that was barely the last drop. What had been happening before?

—Small things… Comments, about everything…— Castaspella sighed, slowly emptying her plate. —Mainly she compares me to Micah, sometimes even to Angella, a few times to herself when she was my age…

—Many small things together weigh more than a single big thing.

—I guess…— she nodded, looking down. —It's just that… none of that should affect me. Not really. Why should I care about how slim Angella looks next to me!? She's also taller! Why should it bother me that I'm "just a librarian" when Micah is "Dean of his own faculty"!? I *chose* to be librarian! I don't want, at all, to be Dean! And why the fuck should I care- Ugh… Never mind…

—What?

—Nothing…

—Something I don't want to know?

—Something silly, actually…

—Just tell me, it's not silly if it's affecting you.

—It shouldn't!

—Es…

—My mother says I cannot be trusted to take care of Glimmer's children when she has them — she finally admitted. —She isn't even pregnant! Why is she talking about that!? Why does it matter to me at all!? Just- Why-why is she so obsessed with me not being "responsible enough", or "mature enough", "successful enough", or just enough for anything!? Why do I *always* do things "wrong" according to her!? If I do something, because I do it; if I *don't* do something, because I didn't do it. *Nothing* satisfies her! At all!

—Es— Light Spinner uttered, unable to stay in place. She immediately stood up and knelt next to her, drying Castaspella's tears with her thumbs. —My Love. Es, listen to me. You don't have to satisfy your mother. You don't *need* to. There is absolutely no reason, at all, to keep listening to her bullshit. She's wrong. She's very wrong, no matter how right she thinks she is— the old woman sternly told her, trying to hold back tears of her own and desperately wanting Castaspella to understand what she meant. —You are enough. You're more than enough. My Love, you're *more than she deserves*.

—You just say that 'cause you love me— she replied, sniffing.

—No, no. I say it because it's a *fact*.

—It's alright. I do-don't mind…— Castaspella lied.

—You do. I know you do. So just… just…— Light Spinner tried to say, but she couldn't find the words and felt a knot on her throat. —Please, please. Hate her. I beg of you. Hate her, get angry at her… don't cry *for her*. She doesn't deserve your tears.

Finally, the young woman looked at her partner, sniffed again, and shook her head, leaning forward to hug her.

—I try. I swear I try. But I can't find it in me to hate her… I don't know why…

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